Haviv siblings in conversation

Interviewer: Thank you very much for agreeing to participate in this focus group. As far as I know, this kind of research has not been conducted before. Researchers most often interview individuals and representatives of families, but not siblings together. What we're doing now - doesn't usually really bring families together, to ask them about things that matter to them. And I'm interested in this little piece. I'm looking at different families across Melbourne, across denominations, and just asking two simple questions. And one of them is: can you describe yourself Jewishly now, where you're at, using your vocabulary? And when you think about your upbringing, what do you see as being any particular influences, events that you, looking back, would attribute to being instrumental in getting you to where you are now?

Would anyone like to go first? First question, Jewishly, where do you see yourself now? Give us a bit of a description of now.

Yehoshua: I always like to be provocative. What do you define as Jewish? Do you want to know where I stand as in from a religious point of view or just as a Jew, in general?

Interviewer: The words that you would use to describe yourself – there are some people who might describe themselves as cultural Jews, others who would describe themselves – they would say that their religion is important to them. Other people might use a denomination to describe themselves or particular labels. You don't need to have terms that other people have designed. You might have your own terms.

Chana: Well, I would say I'm Orthodox Jewish. I'm religious and the **goalposts** for me do change as I grow and as I change as a person. And as a **parent**, I'm constantly questioning why I do things and do I want to be doing certain things, and how do these things make sense to me, and how do I want to pass this onto my kids. I have two little boys. So, I think I'm definitely Orthodox Jewish, if somebody was to ask me to describe it that way. And to think it's very much alive and almost tangible. It's very real for me, I think, because I'm not just going with the flow right now. I'm actively involved because I feel like I'm **consciously** parenting. That's where I stand right now.

Commented [User1]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels participants use to define their substantive identity content rather than relying on researcher-dictated scales.

Chana uses her grandfather's **"soccer game"** metaphor—keeping "blinkers on" to get the "ball in the goal"—to define her current focus on **"consciously parenting"**.
Cross-reference: See comment below (^^)

Interviewer: Chana, if you don't mind me asking, how old are you?

Chana: I'm 29. I've got a four-year-old and almost one-year-old.

Interviewer: And what occupies your days?

Chana: I'm on maternity leave, but I will go back next year to complete my master's. I'm doing cardiac sonography. I've been studying that for a very long time. So among having kids and trying to study, I don't like to be bored! I try to keep myself busy all day, –

Interviewer: With two little kids, it sounds like you don't need to try too hard.

Chana: No, not really.

Interviewer: Right. Cool. Jewishly, what kind of terms would you use, if you had to, to describe yourself?

Chana: As a person?

Interviewer: Yeah. Someone from Melbourne meets you overseas and they say, "Where do you fit, if you do?"

Chana: **I don't fit**. I'm an **openminded** person who likes to **blend** across various different communities, and I don't fit on purpose because I don't want to fit. I like to **explore**. I like to try. I'm also married to someone with the same views and opinions. He's also openminded and constantly **questioning** things. And we're both **not afraid** to go against the **stream** if we have to. We're both **independent** individuals and openminded people. So it's not – whilst things might not be accepted within our communities, we're not afraid to explore another community that better suits us, if need be.

Interviewer: Where were you, congregationally? –

Chana: We're at Shaarei.

Interviewer: Ah. And where are your kids?

Chana: So my four-year-old's at Gilli's creche. The younger one, next year, is going to go to Gillie's Creche, when I go back to work, yeah.

Interviewer: I felt like we had to give back about 25 kilos of sand to that place after the time that my kids were there.

Chana: We have the same problem with sand too –

Interviewer: So true. Yehoshua, tell me about you now.

Yehoshua: So the first one is how do I define myself religiously?

Interviewer: Yeah, or just pretend that I've never met you before in my life and you're introducing yourself to me, giving me a sense of who you are Jewishly, maybe what you're up to, what are you doing, how old are you?

Yehoshua: I define myself as a religious Jew. I tend not to use the words Orthodox or any of those purely because –

Shmul: Stop being so [Modern Orthodox]!

Yehoshua: [Laughing] I'm telling you the truth. I don't use the word – I don't like to use the word Orthodox or any of those things, although from a secular perspective, to give someone that wasn't Jewish an understanding of where I would probably lie, it would be an Orthodox religious Jew. And in doing so, I don't like the stigma of it all just because of – I've gone to – the way I've been raised, I've gone to all the different schools. I started off at [Chassidic school] and I went to [Litvish school], and I had friends in [Chabad school] and [Modern Orthodox school], so I've seen all the spectrum in all the world. And I **don't really fit** myself into **one box**. I've kind of taken **the best of each** thing and that's where I position myself. So that's the way I was raised, so yeah.

Interviewer: Cool. How old are you now and what occupies your days?

Yehoshua: I am 21 years old. I am studying at the moment at RMIT Business Marketing. And on the side, I also run a videography and marketing business when I can, freelance.

Interviewer: Cool. Is that on hold during COVID or still work?

Yehoshua: It's on hold mostly, still a lot of editing work still, so a lot of just digital content creation for people. But otherwise, everything is on hold – put it all on hold for us.

Interviewer: Hopefully, that situation changes soon.

Yehoshua: Hopefully, soon.

Interviewer: Yeah. Cool. Shmul?

Shmul: I'm Shmul. I'm 19. I'm a Catholic.

Interviewer: Mmm.

Shmul: I'm joking. So I do actually – I definitely define myself as Orthodox. I don't know if the word ultra-Orthodox is the right word because I don't know what these words mean really. I don't want to use formal words that I don't understand. So I don't know what to say - I'm not modern Orthodox. I'm a **frum Jew**, a **bocher**. Yeah, I don't think – it's hard for me to describe because it **depends who's asking** the question because if it's my rabbi asking the question, I'd give him one response of where I stand Jewishly. And if a non-Jewish person's asking the question, I'd just say I'm a **strictly observant** Jew, who **wants to grow**. So that's why it's hard for me to answer that question. But what perspective do you want to hear that from?

Interviewer: I'm interested in the way you explain yourself. If you met a Jew overseas and they said, "Oh, I've been to Melbourne. Where did you go to school? Daven?" That might be a way that they figure out who you are.

Shmul: Well, yeah, but at the same time, what I'm trying to say is – I mean religion has got so much depth to – I don't know which aspect, at which point you're asking me. It's like saying, "Oh well, do you play an instrument?" Are you going to go and tell me about your piano and playing Twinkle Little Star and all the songs, or are you just going to – and all the notes and the competitions you've been in, or will you just say, "Yes, I play an **instrument**"? That's what I feel like it is. There's just so much I could say. Yeah. I don't know. I'm definitely strictly observant. The 613 *mitzves*, I strive to keep every single one of them. And even though I know I don't keep every one of them, I know I'm wrong for not keeping the ones that I don't and it's my – every day I work on trying to achieve, to be the best possible Jew I can be and try and keep as many of those 613 to the best extent possible.

Interviewer: Okay. Thank you. Next question. Upbringing. That could mean many things to many people. But let's focus on experiences before you were 18. Chana, you're the firstborn?

Chana: I'm number one.

Interviewer: Okay. Can we start with you?

Chana: Yeah. So –

Interviewer: If you think about your upbringing, are there any particular memories, associations or events, something that you can think of that you think was particularly important in helping you make the decision to be Jewish in the way that you are now?

Chana: Well, I think definitely my education, but also being that I'm the oldest, made me that **parentified child** where I was a **goodie-goodie**. I never questioned anything. I did everything that I was told. I went to [Chassidic school]. All of my cousins at the time were in [Chabad school], so I'd often go to [Chabad youth movement], [Chabad school] Shabbaton. So I was quite **conflicted**, I'd say, or **torn** between both my [Chassidic community] lifestyle and my [Chabad] friends. And then I was allowed to go to [Chabad school] and talk about movies or things like that. Whereas at [Chassidic school], that part of me had to be **shut down** because those things are not allowed to be spoken about back in those days. I think that's all changed now. [Laughs] So I think definitely being in that kind of **cocooned**, protected and very sheltered system in [Chassidic school], but also being exposed to [Chabad school] did teach me to **filter**.

I had a bit of a filter system going on where I'd be at [Chassidic school] and say, "Oh, those values are a little bit too extreme for me." And I'd be at [Chabad school] and say, "Oh, that's a little bit too openminded for me." And at the end of the day, I would just **do whatever I was told**. So up until I maybe – even when I went to seminary, I wasn't necessarily – I'd like to call myself – at the time, **I thought I was an independent thinker, but I was still just doing what I was told**. Even when it came to the seminary that I went to; it was just the one that my parents picked for me. It wasn't until, I think, seminary finished, and **life hit me**, it was, "**Oh wow, now my choice matters now**. Do I want to go to Uni? Do I want to travel? Do I want to just find a job?"

So I think the exposure to [Chabad school] and going on their camps and Shabbatons did help me realise who I was and what I felt most comfortable with because I had to make those kinds of decisions. And again, I would say it did shift once school and seminary were finished, I had to re-evaluate again where do I stand, what to do I want out of life and the next step in life. And again, I think it changed probably from once I got married and had to make choices about where you want to go from there. Another half, I think again, I probably shifted – Yehoshua's going to love this because he always says when I came back from sem I changed. Well, there you go. I think it's because you figure out what you want, what's important to you, what did I like about the way I was raised and what do I take from that and use to move forward really.

Interviewer: Where does home fit? You've spoken a little bit about school and cousins and [Chabad youth movement] -

Chana: Yeah. Home was not particularly strict in terms of being religious. And I think as a woman, I didn't really have **obligations** growing up. I didn't have things to do as a religious girl growing up. Even in high school or anything like that, there wasn't – I didn't have **expectations**. I think probably the only expectation was that I was to dress modestly and that was it. And I think my mother and I had a bit of conflict about that, whether I wanted to wear something that she thought was not appropriate or not suitable because of the community that we were in. But again, I never questioned it. I never felt stifled. I never – if she said no, it was no. I never

Commented [User2]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels participants use to define their substantive identity content rather than relying on researcher-dictated scales.

Chana uses the terms **"parentified child"** and **"goodie-goodie"** to describe her role in the family microsystem.

Commented [User3]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses interactional evidence to distinguish between **"identity optimization"** (refining stable choices) and fundamental crisis, often marking the transition from **conferred** (parental) to **agentic** identity.

Chana describes her transition from a **conferred identity**—where she "was still just doing what I was told"—to an **agentic identity** that emerged only after seminary: "Life hit me, it was, 'Oh wow, now my choice matters now'".

thought that I was allowed to say otherwise. I never thought I was allowed to – even when we were shopping, for example, I would wait for my mother to pull something off the shelf and say, “Do you like this?” It was never, “I like this, and this is what I want to wear.”

But I think, yeah, from a Jewish perspective, I honestly didn’t feel it. I didn’t know what that meant growing up. It was just I did what I was **spoon-fed** to do and that was it.

Interviewer: Do you think sem, in any way, was positive, negative? Was it some kind of provocateur of any kind of thinking, or did that thinking you spoke of occur after –

Chana: No. It definitely wasn’t until a few years later that I reflected on it and was able to grow from it. But at the time, it didn’t actually do much. I was in an environment that was completely not me, and I felt – I did feel uncomfortable in it. I went to a very frum seminary. It’s called Hadar. It still exists. It’s in Jerusalem. It’s very intense. It’s a great place, but it just – I felt like I was the **black sheep in a hall full of the same cattle**, and I just felt really odd. And I had to try as hard as I could to blend in it, but I was – then again, I was pretty good at making myself **blend in** because I was quite used to that. But I did always, at the end of the day, feel a bit weird, like it’s not really where I want to be. But there was no alternative.

It wasn’t like: Oh, I have a voice to be able to say, “I would have preferred to go to another seminary.” But only now, years later, I can look back at that and say, “Wow, I was really lucky to have gone to that seminary with daughters of massive *Rosh Yeshives* in America. I really got to taste what that means, and I really got to experience what that rich kind of *Toireh* lifestyle is that we don’t have here in Melbourne and that – I feel lucky to have had that experience, even though, yeah, it was very tough and challenging, you never do that again. And yeah, it was more about the **learning** for me than it was about the experience and getting to see Israel and all of that. So it did take me a while to be able to look back at it positively.

Interviewer: How long after you came back from sem did you get married?

Chana: I went to sem young. I was 17. Five years, yeah, I got married at 22.

Interviewer: You’re saying that the coming back was that time when you were –

Chana: Honestly, for me, **I figured out who I was through dating, by the experience of meeting other people and actually talk about what your values are and what you want was probably when I discovered who I am**. [Pause] It was the first time that I was almost allowed to have an opinion, allowed to have a voice. I think it was probably a bit stifled growing up. I don’t know if all oldest children experience this or if it was just a part of my nature, but I was scared to say things or scared to give an opinion. I just did what I was told, and I didn’t know you’re allowed to think otherwise. So when I started dating and meeting people, I was quite openminded. I met a lot of different people and I got to experience the real *shiddech* system, as well as interacting with people that I had met myself. And a lot of it really taught me about who I am.

Interviewer: Wow. You said at the beginning that you think you’re still an evolving concept.

Chana: Absolutely.

Commented [User4]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels participants use to define their substantive identity content rather than relying on researcher-dictated scales.

Chana describes herself as a **"black sheep in a hall full of the same cattle"** at her seminary, illustrating her sense of "otherness" within a rigid system.

Commented [User5]: 2. Disambiguating ‘Searching’ through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses interactional evidence to distinguish between **"identity optimization"** (refining stable choices) and fundamental crisis, often marking the transition from **conferred** (parental) to **agentic** identity.

Chana describes the **"Searching Moratorium paradox"** through the lens of her dating experience, noting it was the first time she was **"allowed to have an opinion"** and a **"voice,"** representing an active move toward self-definition.

Interviewer: Is there a Judaism of you, or it's more about a Judaism of the family or co-creating? Are they the same?

Chana: [Long pause] Yeah. Yeah. I think it's the same. As a woman, I believe it's more **emotional**. It's about the **feeling**. It's about **connecting** and it's less, for me, about the rituals that I perform or – I don't have to daven and I don't have to put on tefillin and things like that. But it's about **finding beauty** every day and say, "Oh wow, I recognise that there's a God and I – thank you, Hashem, for this beautiful flower that's in my garden." And to me, that's an emotional moment. And to me, that's religion. And to me, that's Judaism. And if I can pass that onto my kids, then I feel happy. And I think, yeah, as a woman, it is more for me about feeling and how I feel and emotionally, how I connect. And I think like all kinds of inspiration, the feelings come, and the feelings go and it's about how you act on it in the moment when I do feel inspired.

So it could be I heard a shiur, or I read an interesting article and then I feel that moment of inspiration and connection. Something I do at home when I do read something inspiring, I often cut it out and stick it on my fridge. So it's like it **hangs on**. The inspiration hangs on and my family gets to see it. And we all get to try and live by it and keep that **spark** alive.

Interviewer: Sounds beautiful. Yehoshua? Upbringing?

Yehoshua: So the same way Chana calls herself the first child, I was always classified as the first boy, although I am the middle. I've got an older sister and two younger brothers. And as the first boy, I was the – much like Chana would say – I was the trial experiment of all the Jewish things that a boy does. And I think my – as a kid, I probably never recognised it, but growing up, I definitely did. My mother was the person who taught me to live by religion and believe in it and the inspiration behind it and the love for it, and to recognise everything behind it. And my father taught me the discipline of religion, that sometimes you just do things because that's what we need to do. And in doing so, you find the happy medium between the inspirational and the doing.

It's like putting on tefillin and getting up every morning and going to shul on time. And my father didn't do that by educating, he did it purely by leading by example. So as a kid growing up, my father was always **the big scary guy** who we'd never mess with when it came to doing anything Jewish. When he said, "You go to shul," you went to shul. And my mum was always the first – like we could **tweak** and do it, but she was very much from a religious standpoint, **always pushing us to be happy about where we stand religiously**.

Growing up and school, I was all hell to the school and to my parents, 100%. I broke every single rule and pushed every boundary, not from a – being interruptive in class, but just I – for the six years, I spent my time in [Chassidic school]. And in doing so, I didn't – I felt like I did so much purely because I had to and not because I wanted to. And I had, for example, *gemoreh* forced down my throat so much. We started learning in [Chassidic school] at the age of – in year three already, *gemoreh*. So from that age, we were pushed in *gemoreh* and I had a complete dislike to it, turned away, said I'm never going to do it again. And no matter then how much I tried, even after changing schools, I could never regain that thirst of learning. So from a physical, inhouse learning, I have a major **complex** in my upbringing and I don't think that has to do with my parents at home. It has to do with my schooling.

Commented [User6]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Relational-Level (Micro/Micro-systemic): The siblings trace their identity standards to their **grandfather**, who is described as the **"root of all of our non-conforming issues"** and the standard to which they all aspire. Yehoshua describes the **"good cop, bad cop"** dynamic of his parents, where his father provided **"discipline"** and his mother provided **"inspiration"**.

Cross-reference: Theme continues also below (@@)

Commented [User7]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Relational-Level (Micro/Micro-systemic): The siblings trace their identity standards to their **grandfather**, who is described as the **"root of all of our non-conforming issues"** and the standard to which they all aspire. Yehoshua describes the **"good cop, bad cop"** dynamic of his parents, where his father provided **"discipline"** and his mother provided **"inspiration"**.

Cross-reference: Theme continues also (@@)

And I would always come home from school and my mum would always say to me – and my dad would just be like, “Don’t worry about it. You just need to go to shul and stick to your – **sometimes you do things and eventually, you fall in love doing** – he **led by that example**.

When my grandfather passed away, he started learning mishnayes every single year. And I watched him go from doing it every single year just because he decided to set a goal, and finishing mishnayes every year to now he loves it and every time he’s got a free break, he pulls out mishnayes. So **I’ve learned to learn that discipline**. Eventually, you can find the love in it. And my mother would always – I would come home, and she would just say, “Forget about it. That’s not something that you need to – it’s not going to define you as a religious person. The person that you are religiously is not the person who **believes**.” So I was always someone that was not a duck to water when it came to schooling and when it came to religion. I pushed every **boundary**.

All the way until growing up, I pushed it all. As I left Yesodei – there’s only two students that ever went into high school at Yesodei and I’m one of them and the other one is also an [Chassidic school] boy. And ever since, they have officially made a rule they’re no longer accepting boys at the high school, straight into high school from [Chassidic school]. That’s a true story. We’ve caused them a lot of grief.

Interviewer: Is it called – it’s called the Haviv rule?

Yehoshua: Yeah. Exactly. After leaving school, I went to yeshiveh for two years. And growing up – I always find that - we always discuss it now, in hindsight, with 20/20 vision, that Chana got a much stricter upbringing than me in the sense –

Chana: **It’s so interesting because as you’re talking about it, I’m thinking to myself: You know what? Our parents got a lot stricter when the boys were born** because for some reason, I think they believed religion on the boys is much more important than it is on the girl.

Yehoshua: Yeah. Exactly.

Chana: So **from my perspective, I didn’t have strict parenting at all**. I don’t see what you’re saying.

Yehoshua: **So I see, from my perspective, a stricter parenting** – just from hearing your stories of the past and you had to dress like this and my parents never said that. My mum loves to repeat this story. When I was a kid, I fell off a bike and my mum said to me, “You know why you fell off the bike? It’s because you weren’t wearing your yarmulke.” And I said to her, “Hashem doesn’t need – Hashem can still recognise me without my yarmulke.” And I was five years old. And to this day, that’s my mum being like, “See, I managed to instil G-d in you! No matter what.”

Chana: She would never say that today.

Yehoshua: 100%, she does. She still does. So yeah, I always found that the **good cop, bad cop** played an interesting role in my life with my mum being very relaxed and teaching me just the love it all and my father teaching me discipline.

Commented [User8]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Individual-Level: Yehoshua connects his school experience (having *gemoreh* "forced down his throat") to his individual **"complex"** regarding traditional learning. Shmul connects his mother's background of **"jumping schools"** to his own sense of being an **"outsider"** who doesn't fit into a single box.

Cross-reference: Theme continues (##)

Commented [User9]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Relational-Level (Micro/Micro-systemic): The siblings trace their identity standards to their **grandfather**, who is described as the **"root of all of our non-conforming issues"** and the standard to which they all aspire. Yehoshua describes the **"good cop, bad cop"** dynamic of his parents, where his father provided **"discipline"** and his mother provided **"inspiration"**.

Cross-reference: Theme continues also (@@)

Commented [User10]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme identifies **"interactional action units"** where siblings act as **"truth-checkers"** who instantly corroborate or challenge individual self-schemas to disrupt the distortion of family narratives.

Yehoshua attempts to frame the family history by claiming that Chana had a **"much stricter upbringing"** than him. Chana immediately intervenes with a **repair sequence**, contradicting his perception: "I really don’t... I don’t really – I think I was just going with the flow".

Commented [User11]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme identifies **"interactional action units"** where siblings act as **"truth-checkers"** who instantly corroborate or challenge individual self-schemas to disrupt the distortion of family narratives.

Yehoshua claims their parents became stricter when the boys were born. Chana provides **relational verification**, agreeing that "our parents got a lot stricter when the boys were born because for some reason, I think they believed religion on the boys is much more important".

But then when I went to yeshiveh, I learned something completely new, which was that my entire upbringing comprised of two things, the things that I wanted to do, the things that I loved and were genuine core beliefs. And the things that were just community and parental standards that I did because I had to – and I went to yeshiveh and I had no one around me and I only spoke to my parents once every two days. And they weren't there to see me. Anything that I didn't care about stripped away. So for me, that was not wearing a hat on Shabbes. That fell away because I didn't find it added value to my religious life. And **all of a sudden, it stripped me down to my core** and I realised there's only five or six essential principles that I genuinely believe in. I hated gemoreh. I went through two years yeshiveh and I hated it, the gemoreh aspect of it. There were parts that I loved, but I pushed through it. And I loved the overall experience of yeshiveh and being surrounded 24/7 by people who were Toiredik and 24/7 by people who learn and have a love for the Toireh, but I could never grasp gemoreh. But I learned so much more from a personal value perspective. And nothing I learned there was new. I never learned anything new. I just learned to pull out what I had already known, and thought was taught at home and pulled out what I appreciated of that and make it for myself.

And as a kid – and one of my biggest – I guess the reason why I was such a devil in school and always a pain to people was because I so strongly stood by my principles and values that I got raised at my home, that I said, "No matter what you tell me, that's how it is. That's what my parents do. That's what my grandfather did. And at home, we were always taught to aspire to be like my grandfather, who was very well-established in the community. So we, the whole time, were pushed to that level and to this day, I still think that's my ultimate.

To this day, I go, "That's my goal," or, "How can I achieve that perfect balance, that balance of religious but secular – being able to build it from home, and thank God, all my grandfather's grandkids are, on the majority part, religious. How do you create that ripple effect? And it's not just by forcing to learn gemoreh, which is what my resentment always was. So my upbringing was this give and take. I can never define where I am. I've become a bit of a chameleon to everything. I've learned to adapt. If I go to a very Chassidish place – because I went to [Chassidic school], I pronounce Hebrew words in a Chassidish way. When I go to anywhere else, then I don't. So I've learned to adapt and people here from – what they need to hear. But my core values are all from home. Nothing is from my education system. Nothing is from yeshiveh. I've just learned to put it all together and create one big aspect out of it.

Interviewer: Right. And is this your second year back from yeshiva?

Yehoshua: This is my first year back from yeshiveh. So exactly 10 months ago I was in yeshiveh for two years, was thinking about doing a third and my father said, "Absolutely not, not paying for another year of partying." [Laughs] And that's it, came home.

Interviewer: Were you in the same yeshiva as Shmul? The same place?

Yehoshua: Yeah, we were in the same yeshiveh. I spent the first year on my own and then Shmul actually joined me in my second year.

Commented [User12]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses interactional evidence to distinguish between **"identity optimization"** (refining stable choices) and fundamental crisis, often marking the transition from **conferred** (parental) to **agentic** identity.

Yehoshua describes his yeshiva experience as a process of **identity optimization**. He notes that being away from home **"stripped"** away community standards he didn't care about, leaving him with a "core" of five or six essential principles. This confirms he was refining a stable commitment rather than undergoing a crisis.

Commented [User13]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels participants use to define their substantive identity content rather than relying on researcher-dictated scales.

Yehoshua describes himself as a **"chameleon"** who can **"blend"** into different communal **"postcodes,"** code-switching his Hebrew pronunciation depending on the audience.

(Cross-reference: Another example below **)

Interviewer: **Right. Chana, can I just jump back to you? Yehoshua was saying that he had a different parenting experience, a different school experience. I'm wondering what your experience was –**

Chana: I really don't. I don't really – I think I was just going with the **flow**. I never felt – no, I can't say I experienced it the same way Yehoshua did. I have wonderful memories. I have difficult memories. I remember feeling very **lonely**, but it has nothing to do – I remember feeling lonely because I'm the eldest in my family. My sister's four years younger than me. So when I was going through school, I didn't have any cousins or family friends. I was the first to be going to [Chassidic school] and I felt very **apart** and **separate**. And it took probably until high school until I felt comfortable being there. I don't have negative feelings about it and it wasn't a bad experience. If only – I think to myself what I would want for my child, a better sense of **belonging**, but I would want that in any circumstance.

It has nothing to do with being Jewish necessarily. I think it's just I didn't feel that I belonged there for some reason or that I did belong there, and I just didn't feel **connected** enough. And that just could be because I didn't have any other family there or a sibling around at the same time.

Yehoshua: It becomes this – I don't know how to explain it, but within [Chassidic community], it's [Chassidic community] supports [Chassidic community] in their own little bubble. And I agree with Chana. Well, the thought that always runs through my mind is how can I – if I ever had kids, how would pass on – I'm the happiest person when it comes to religion. I think I've got the best in between and ultimate that anyone has ever had. I've never met anyone else other than my own family that has managed to find this perfect understanding of I can go to a Chassidish house and get why they do what they do and why they're Chassidish and why they believe it and why they want to do what they do. And I can respect it and, in some ways, I do a lot of the things they do just without the whole dress-up. And then on the flip side, I can go somewhere else and I can completely understand when I daven at [Modern Orthodox synagogue], I completely understand why some people behave in some way and the way they daven and the way – the things that they care about and their core values.

And I always say – of my whole family, the way I see it – and Shmul can tell me otherwise – but when I grew up, I always saw my – from what I heard, my two sisters always had it a bit more stricter than me but in a very different way. The two people that **hated school** the most and struggled the most are me and my youngest brother, Menachem. I literally – I could see him replicating every move that I've done and every single year level because he's got the same issue that I had in that year level.

And then I always saw Shmul as someone who graduated from [Chassidic school]. I saw him when he finished at [Chassidic school]. To me, it was the system. I don't know if it worked for him, but it flowed well with him. So for me, I just find our whole experience and our whole family is just – we all somehow walked out with the same idealistic views. I don't know how it happened. We all did schooling in our own way. Of all of us, Menachem is going to be the only one that grew up in a single school –

Shmul: No, he didn't. He only went there at the age 10.

Commented [User14]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Macro-Level (Systemic): Shmul describes the **"system"** of the Chassidic school which refused to allow VCE for fear of setting a precedent that would "turn the entire school over". Yehoshua discusses the **"little bubble"** of the Chassidic community where everyone supports one another.

Cross-reference: Theme continues below ($$)

Yehoshua: Yeah. But no, but that's – but even then, he'd – no, he went there Shmul in year four.

Shmul: Year three, year three.

Yehoshua: So I'm saying from year – yeah, but Shmul, in year three, we didn't learn anything. In year three, we didn't learn anything yet. Year three was the year I started learning *gemoreh* at [Chassidic school]. Year three is the year you started learning *gemoreh* at [Chassidic school]. They started learning in year five. I'm saying that's – he only started to – he's essentially been brought up in Yesodei –

Shmul: And he stayed down –

Yehoshua: And I think that of – yeah, somehow he's the only one – I find that because we went to our different schools and we learned to adapt, we all built this understanding of how to respect the other person's core beliefs. And Menachem, we're watching – it's not – we're seeing it's a little bit different. He doesn't get Chassidish people as well as we do because –

Chana: What you're saying about blending in different communities, I can also relate to that. When I was in Sem them – and my classmate from Meah Shearim came to visit us and half of the seminary was shocked, like how do you know to speak Yiddish to this girl? And how do you know her and how do you even know someone from Toldos Ahren? And I can also blend in that way –

Yehoshua: But we never grew up with the belonging in an exact community. That's the one thing –

Chana: And that's exactly what I was going to say. That's exactly –

Yehoshua: The one thing we always – what my point I was getting at is we can't pinpoint – Shmul used to yell at my mum about this. It's like how do you actually define what community I'm in? I didn't grow up in a single school. I didn't grow up in a single community. My friends are not from one community. I didn't grow up with them. I only met them when I was 18 because I left – I was **bumping between communities**. [Then again] I always say, "How can I give my child that experience of being able to understand all the communities, but grew up in one where they have their set friends and their set families that they know?" We never got that.

Chana: It leaves you feeling a little bit **lost**, and that's why – I mean look at us. We've moved three different shuls and still don't feel like Shaarei is home. Will there ever be a place that's **home**? I don't know, but there's – exactly like what you said, you get so used to **blending** in other communities that you don't have your **roots** in one.

Yehoshua: Yeah. No, I definitely relate to that as well. Yeah.

Interviewer: Shmul?

Shmul: Yeah. I think, for me, upbringing is interesting because I wasn't the first boy. I was basically – you feel as the middle, but he wasn't the middle child because I was the middle of three boys. And I feel like Yehoshua was – the age gap between Yehoshua and Chana – and Suri is much bigger than me and Yehoshua. We're 18 months apart. And so I was right underneath Yehoshua and Yehoshua was the

Commented [User15]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme identifies **"interactional action units"** where siblings act as **"truth-checkers"** who instantly corroborate or challenge individual self-schemas to disrupt the distortion of family narratives.

The siblings engage in a literal debate over the historical details of their brother Menachem's schooling. Shmul corrects Yehoshua on whether Menachem started at age 10 or in Year 3. This exemplifies the **intersubjective grounding** required to prevent the creation of unchecked family myths.

Commented [User16]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels participants use to define their substantive identity content rather than relying on researcher-dictated scales.

Yehoshua describes himself as a **"chameleon"** who can **"blend"** into different communal **"postcodes,"** code-switching his Hebrew pronunciation depending on the audience.
(Another example below **)

(Cross-reference: another example of this above **)

***Moishe Rabbeini* breaking the water**. And then I was behind. And I'm just like, "Yeah." But I don't relate to Yehoshua about his hardships and stuff through school because I was very **go with the flow** and I hated change. So I was always happy in the environment I was in, and I wasn't – I didn't have the intellectual independence or ability, at a young age, to go, "What does this mean? Is this ever going to affect me? Is this – any of that. I couldn't ask – yeah, I don't think I was smart enough to ask any questions to think: Oh, am I genuinely happy?

I just think I was a good kid. I had friends. I had lots of friends. My friends were always older than me. They were never the most – the average, normal friends from normal school kids above me, younger than me, whatever it was, I was never – I had friends from all over the place and I went to [Chassidic school] and I knew I didn't fit it in [Chassidic school for years because – and I think I was all right up until about year eight. But when I went into yeshiveh ketaneh, I knew it wasn't happening there. And I was doing **VCE *in* yeshiveh ketaneh**! And they wanted to kick me out. I only found this out years later, that they were going to – when Rav […] died, I found this out, that they were going to kick me out because the rabbi of yeshiva ketaneh, Rav […], the Rosh Yeshiveh, said, "No, there's no such thing. There's no such thing as doing VCE in [Chassidic school]. If he does it, he's going to set a precedent and the whole school, everyone's going to want to do VCE and all the parents, and it's going to turn the entire school over. We're maintaining a system. You can't change a system."

But in year nine, there was three options. You could do an hour of English a day from Rabbi […], who taught you how to sign cheques. You could do two or three hours a day, which was up until about – at about three o'clock every day, you'd go to [Chassidic school] and you'd do that for three hours chol, like three to six, the last three hours, or the third option was all-day koidesh. And I'd say 85% of my class did all-day koidesh. 10% of my class did Rabbi […]. And the last 5% of my class, which was two boys sometimes, sometimes one boy – one of the parents forced the kids to do it. The other kid was a Yesodei boy, so he wanted to do it. And I was the only kid who actually was **meant to be there**. There was one – so it was always between three to one kid every day. So that was that.

And my parents said, "No, he's doing VCE. Two or three hours isn't enough for him. We need time for him to be tutored. We need time for him to be taught." They said, "We want him to take off night seider as well." And the yeshiva ketaneh flipped it and they wanted to kick me out. And they went to Rav [head of the congregation] and he said *"E'chop hakoores ha'toiv u'far Zaideh?* I'm not kicking him out," which meant he had *hakores ha'toiv* for my grandfather because my grandfather built the community and did so much for the community over so many years. He's not going to kick me out of this. He's not going to – he's going to let me do –

Chana: Who told you -

Shmul: What?

Chana: Who told you?

Shmul: I never knew this story.

Chana: Who told you?

Commented [User17]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels participants use to define their substantive identity content rather than relying on researcher-dictated scales.

Shmul refers to Yehoshua as **"Moishe Rabbeini breaking the water"** [Moses splitting the sea], a metaphor for the older brother acting as a path-breaker through the family's religious "system".

Commented [User18]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Macro-Level (Systemic): Shmul describes the **"system"** of the Chassidic school which refused to allow VCE for fear of setting a precedent that would "turn the entire school over". Yehoshua discusses the **"little bubble"** of the Chassidic community where everyone supports one another.

Cross-reference: Theme appears also above ($$)

Shmul: Well, I'll tell you in a second. I never knew this story for years. And I don't even know if my parents know this story. And the way I heard the story was because I became very close to one of the rabbis from school. And when Rav […] died, I used to learn with this rabbi. And I said to him – it was crazy. "You know Rav […] saved you. You wouldn't be in [Chassidic school] if not for Rav […]." And I'm like, "Stop saying – everyone says that." And he goes, "No." And he told me the story. He says, "I remember being in the staffroom and Rav […] was trying his hardest to make sure that I wouldn't do it." And rightfully so, it was a system. You don't break systems.

But my mother's background was they jumped schools all the time – they never went in one place. They were in hundreds of different schools and my mother's parents **sacrificed** everything for education. And my mother was prepared to do the same. She wasn't going to stop because Rav […] says no. She was going to **fight** until the end. And she was thinking about moving to Yesodei and she was thinking about all these things and she knew I wanted to be in [Chassidic school], so she fought for it. And she wanted me to be in [Chassidic school]. And I was happy. I was happy, but I knew I wasn't meant to be there because the kids would wear – they were just in a different **ballgame**. They were in white shirts and suits and I was never like that. And I'd wear a white shirt, but that was about it.

I knew I used to go to Spot-On every morning and I was just mucking around, always causing trouble, and I knew I wasn't meant to be there. But I had a good time and my friends loved me, so it was never so hard for me. And then what happened was I finished yeshiva ketaneh in year 11, and I wasn't going there much. In year 11 and I'd wag school and whatever. And then I started doing VCE and in year 12, I did VCE all the way through and I was still okay because I was friends with – I was at a lot of friends. I was at home. I was on my own. I had lots of friends of all sorts of ages and I'd hang out with those friends. I was busy with my business.

I kept myself busy and I was always at home and I was sheltered. But like Chana and Yehoshua said, what the second – I went overseas. Yehoshua has a much more positive experience and I think for Chana, maybe it was somewhere there was a balance of some positives and some negatives. But when I went overseas, I really was torn. And this was the first time I felt it was I had nowhere to go because I didn't want to go to Medrash because I wasn't where I ended up going because it's not me and I didn't want to go to the same place as Yehoshua because I'm not like Yehoshua. We're different. We're independent people. And I didn't want to go to a Chassidish place even though that's what I like because I'm not Chassidish. I'm so far from it. And I couldn't go to [Modern Orthodox synagogue] or B'nei where some of my friends went because I'm not B'nei. And I have never gone to a B'nei thing and I really was torn and I didn't want to go to YG because I wasn't Chabad. And I was torn. And I wanted to go to YG, but there were like – my friends just laughed, and my parents just laughed. They said, "Yeah, you want to go to YG. They're never going to take you," which they wouldn't have. I shaved my beard. I have a choop. I don't use Rabbeinu Tam. I'm not Lubavitch. It's not an option. So I was stuck between all these things and then I was like, "You know what? That's it. I'm not going to yeshiveh. I'm just going to go to university."

And I was ready to do that. And my father was like, "No problem." He was like, "You want to do that? No problem. You have to make a whole structure every day of what time you're going to get up, what time you're going to this, what time – and

Commented [User19]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Individual-Level: Yehoshua connects his school experience (having *gemoreh* "forced down his throat") to his individual **"complex"** regarding traditional learning. Shmul connects his mother's background of **"jumping schools"** to his own sense of being an **"outsider"** who doesn't fit into a single box.

Cross-reference: Theme continues (##)

then everything you want to do, you do it. I don't let you – I'm not going to let you just hang around and roam the streets. You have to have a schedule every day." And I said, "Well, you made it sound like **bootcamp**." So I was like, "You know what?" I wanted to go to Italy with my friend at the end of the year. So I thought I'll go there and after that I'll do yeshiveh. And I wanted to book a ticket to come home in January before uni starts. My father's like, "No, we'll book it for Pesach and you'll stay, and you'll figure it out. You'll figure it out whether you want to stay or you want to come home, you can come home."

So I went there until Pesach and I didn't really like it. I hated it. I didn't feel – I was in Medrash and it was a good place because it had a mix of all sorts of boys. So in some way, it was a balance between something. But it wasn't – I couldn't find my place to fit in. And I became friends with these boys who were Lubavitch who I had a better association with because they had a bit more of the Chassidish background, but they were still chilled and normal like I was. And I didn't like it. And I came back – no, I pushed it until Pesach and then I'm like, "No, I'm not going back." And my parents were like, "Give it one more shot." And when I went back, I met South African boys who I had very much felt were very similar to me in terms of background. South Africa has a very similar community for these kids and they were frum kids, but they would have fun. We'd go out. We'd party. We'd drink. But we still had proper religious values. And for the first time, I was enjoying being overseas because I was with similar like people. But I knew I still had an issue of I don't fit in. Anywhere. And yeah, and then from there, whatever it was, I ended up doing a year of *yeshiveh* and I ended up going to New York where I had made friends and I jumped around –

Yehoshua: And now you're home and you're a *shaigetz*!

Shmul: My friends would joke when I was in yeshiveh that I – they'd joke and they'd say to me, one of the shluchim said, "Next year you're going to be in Biyahn when you find something better because you're just going through your Chabad phase right now," because he knew. He was like, "You've gone, and you don't belong anywhere." And even at the Chabad *yeshiveh*, I remember one time I bought crackers and they weren't pas yisroel, and Chabad is very big on pas yisroel. When I grew up to Melbourne, I didn't know what pas yisroel is, right. So they go, "Oh, whose are these crackers? They're not pas yisroel." And the rabbi was going to chuck them. And then someone was like, "Oh, I think they're Shmul's." And he was like, "Oh, that's okay. It's fine," because I was surrounded by, in a sense – and this is a huge generalisation, but people who are intellectually dependent, people who are uneducated, people who are uncultured, right – and I have nothing against them. These are my best friends, my best rabbis, but they only ever grew up seeing one thing. These Chabad kids saw one thing. These Chassidish kids saw one thing. So wherever I went, I was always a bit of the **outsider**. And some places loved it, some places hate it. And yeah, I mean it gave me a sense of **independence**, but it came at a **huge cost**.

Yehoshua: I think that my experience of being friends that stay with – in university, I've got a bunch of friends who in B'nei. And I always find when they discuss things and I discuss things, they laugh at me. And I find that they laugh at me not because they think it's weird, just because they don't understand. I find that those who have grown up in one community, and this is my issue with people, how do you raise a kid that grows up in one community but has that open view? I find that they're like this. They're like a horse with the blinds on them.

Commented [User20]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems***,* showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Individual-Level: Yehoshua connects his school experience (having *gemoreh* "forced down his throat") to his individual **"complex"** regarding traditional learning. Shmul connects his mother's background of **"jumping schools"** to his own sense of being an **"outsider"** who doesn't fit into a single box.

Cross-reference: Theme continues (##)

Interviewer: Blinkers.

Yehoshua: Yeah. Exactly.

Shmul: We all are. We all are.

Yehoshua: And if you told them anything outside of that box – and if their core values are not strong and they don't genuine believe in what they believe, then you tell them something here, they have to revoke it or laugh at it because it shudders their system. For a split second, you're actually provoking their belief. And I find that – of all the kids that – I don't know. I always think our family is crazy because each one of us have found our own little thing. We've all come to this conclusion of upbringing. But we all did it in different ways. And I think that – I find that of the whole family, myself and Menachem are the two – and this is not a bad thing to anyone else I'm saying – are the two only people who grew up as kids and constantly provoking.

I would provoke my rabbis every single day. Why do you do this? And I'll do it just to piss them off. I wouldn't do it – I'd do it just to see are they genuine, and if so, do I want to learn from that? Because I needed to be able to replicate that. And I would provoke even myself the whole time. I remember – and my mother would love that I provoked so long as I came back to some kind of root. I remember the day before I broke my leg – I don't know if any of you know this, but the day before I broke my leg, which was exactly when Chana got engaged –

Chana: Married, a week before –

Yehoshua: A week before Chana got married, two weeks, that I got – I was yelling and crying at my mother and my father that I hated school. I was in Yesodei. I hate *koidesh*. I don't want to do it anymore, don't want to do it. There's no point in *koidesh* and I literally yelled, bawling my eyes out, saying, "I don't even think Hashem cares," blah, blah, blah. Six hours later, I break my leg. Everyone's going to take their [pshat] out of it. To me, that's my **calling** of its own thing. But that was me being **provocative**. I grew up being provocative and Menachem's the exact same. He will go up to his rabbis and say, "Why are we learning *gemoreh*?" And if they can't answer him, then he's winning. And I'm a big believer in that. If you can't – if when I provoke you shudders your core beliefs, then I don't believe it's a core belief for you.

Shmul: Yeah, it's interesting. It's very interesting because I don't think I'm provocative. I think I'm the opposite. I think that when rabbis would tell me things, I'd just nod my head. I'd be like, "Yeah, you're absolutely right." And then I'd leave, and I'd do whatever I do anyway. And then I'd go to my next rabbi and I'd be like, "Yeah, you're absolutely right," because I also surrounded myself – often, I found myself with **extremists**. My chassidish rabbis were telling me things and asking *"Vos is doos?"* that I have a dumb phone. And they'd be like vos is doos." And that was the phone that I hid in my pocket, so I didn't – they didn't see my smartphone and my laptop and my iPad and my computer and my four other iPads and computers, right. So I lied to him. And when he told me, "Vos is doos?" I said, "Yeah, you're right. It's very bad. I have a dumb phone." And when I went to Lubavitch and the rabbis would sit in there telling me the Rebbe is *Melech Ha'Moshiach*, I said, "You're right. I'm calling to your understanding he's *Moshiach* and I didn't ever disagree, but I know he's not *Moshiach*. I didn't ever fight with anyone. I just took it and just continued on. And I don't know if I found the medium in between everyone.

Chana: Yeah, I'm with Shmul.

Yehoshua: I mean if anyone asks, I spent my whole yeshiveh and never wore a white shirt. I refuse to wear white shirts. Sometimes I would, and if I did it, it was because I wanted to look good that day not because I wore a white shirt to yeshiveh. I hate white shirts. I hate the idea that's behind it. I hate that people have a stigma in Israel and soldiers would look at kids' white shirts and despise them because they would just correlate the protestors with Hareidim. Yeah, I didn't like it all. I put on a blue shirt every single day and looked great. But I didn't – that was my provoking. Sometimes I provoke and I don't necessarily believe. Sometimes I'll provoke just for the sake of provoking because I think I grew up in a way that I was always provoked.

And that I always wanted to make sure that I believed in something, that when a rabbi would tell me to do something, I'd provoke him just to make sure that he's strong enough for me to – I find that when I have a rabbi, I want to emulate the things that he does. That's what a rabbi is there for. And I provoke him and if he can provoke me back, then that's my way of mutual understanding. I never went with the **flow**.

Interviewer: I'm interested, Chana –your sister's not part of the focus group and I'm not going to ask you to speak for her, but do you think that the big difference between – or that the difference between your upbringing experience and your brothers' is influenced by gender, birth order, or do you think that there might be something else that – because you were saying basically – well, Yehoshua was saying that he was the firstborn, as well as you being the firstborn?

Chana: Definitely between the time I was born and Yehoshua was born, my mother's parenting style changed. And I don't know whether that was a conscious decision. One tiny little example is when I was growing up, we had a TV at home. When Yehoshua was born – was it when you were born?

Yehoshua: Yeah, exactly when I was born.

Chana: Yeah. When Yehoshua was born, my mother made the move and she said, "I don't want to raise boys with a TV at home." And she got rid of it. So I think that was the start of something. For some reason, raising boys – my parents felt the home needs to be safer, more protected. They're probably right. Boys is a bit of a different game and my mother felt like those girls probably will be more gentle and we'll do whatever we're told. I don't know. I'm thinking of Suri and how she would answer these questions, and I don't know where she would stand, whether she's more like me and Shmul or if she's a bit more like Yehoshua. When Suri and I talk about our childhood though and our upbringing, we had very, very different experiences and we perceive it very differently. So I don't know how much is 'nature' because we're also quite different, versus whether the parenting style changed or the school system changed. I don't really know.

Interviewer: You've all spoken about school in some way. Shmul, you spoke about friends actually keeping you in yeshiva, that all of you –

Yehoshua: That, for me, was **home**.

Interviewer: And so in terms of friends, I mean do they matter? In terms of in your upbringing, were they –

Chana: In our upbringing, we were raised that you don't need friends. At least I was raised that way and that's much to do with the way my mother was raised because they moved countries so often; you don't need friends to be happy. You should be happy on your own. So I was raised that you don't need friends. I always did have a handful of close friends. And today, my closest friends – my closest friend lives in London and she's English. We connected when we were in our 20s and we just really found each other, and we've never lived together ever, ever, ever. It's always been this virtual friendship in a way. I'm wondering if we ever did live together, would we be friends? I don't know. But I think in terms of friendships, yeah, our friends – or my friends are very **colourful** across the **spectrum** because you don't need to have close friends. You don't need to have best friends. I think that I miss it. There definitely have been times I wished that it was different, but I probably don't even know how. And I think that has to do with upbringing. And I mean look at my mother. She has friends from every community. She's a very vibrant personality and can blend into many communities and has many friends. But at the end of the day, where do your *closest* friends come from? I think my closest friends are still from school. I think –

Shmul: Really?

Chana: Because –

Yehoshua: Yeah, I'm the total opposite.

Chana: – I spent the most time with them. I have a couple of friends from seminary. And yeah, I think – yeah, Suri and I talk about that a lot, that we weren't encouraged ever to have friends.

Yehoshua: That's interesting because when I grew up in school, my friends that I have today – although they are very good friends of mine – are probably friends more by circumstance and the fact that they were the people that were in my community and my social groups that kind of worked. Then it would be like saying, "Yeah, this is my best mate. This is my soulmate. This is just someone I'm just really close with." And I was always like this, but I guess someone once put it into good words for me when I was in *yeshiveh*. As a kid growing up, I always found that when I was in the system or when I was surrounded by really, really educated, religiously educated people, I hated learning. I found that when – and someone summed it up very well. When you're in a room, it's much easier to be a good learner in a room full of bad learners than it is to be a good learner in a room full of good learners because I would constantly bring myself down and question my core values when I was surrounded by other people that could learn *gemoreh*, for example. That was always my provoking thing. When I was back home, I'm the happiest. I find that I missed more days - *tefillin* - in *yeshiveh* than I did at home. I found that when I was in that environment, it was constantly provoking me. And yeah, my friend groups didn't really influence my – they didn't influence it in a positive way necessarily. My friend wouldn't say to me, "Let's learn," and now I'm inspired to learn. It had to be from me or nothing.

Shmul: Yeah. Well, I think I'm different again. Look, I definitely – I think like Chana said, my parents had a very strong – my mother, not my father – my father was always more **subtle** about these things. And if he ever sensed – if he ever said something – that my father ever said something – until today, if my father says something to me, he doesn't say a lot. And when he says something, I'll do it. I don't care what

cost it comes at. Whereas if my mother says something, very often it **goes over my head**. But I think my mother had more of an impact, more – she never liked my friends, and I don't think she liked any of my siblings' friends really until –

Yehoshua: Never. Never.

Shmul: Weird. "This friend comes from a broken home. I'm a bit worried. This friend is a bit estranged. This friend is not"–

Chana: I guess I picked good friends because I was never told off.

Shmul: Yeah. My mother never – not didn't like them, she was critical of them. And some of my friends, who today are my closest friends, my mother did not like the first few times she met them. But then she became openminded and eventually saw them and learned we've – got to meet them and got to know them. But I guess she was always very – her view was first I want to suspect them and when I get to know them, once they've earned it, I'll respect them. But I'm not just going to give them the time of the day yet. So it was very interesting for us, but for me, more than Chana and Yehoshua for sure, my friends are everything, everything. If my friends did something – if my friends jumped off a bridge, I'd probably jump off the bridge with them, not to that extent but just –

Yehoshua: He suffers from peer pressure.

Shmul: In school, when the teacher said, "Why did you do this?" And I said, "Because my friend did it." And they'd say, "If your friend jumped off the bridge, shouldn't you jump off the bridge?" I don't think I'd jump off the bridge, but if my friends decided tomorrow that they're going to Israel, they're renting an apartment and we're just going to have fun, I'd go with them because they're my circ -. The weird thing is it's not like my friends are one circle, all my friends in a circle. This friend and this friend have never met, never will meet and won't ever get along. So I've got a very wide range of friends, but I think they're extremely influential. And I found the balance between all of these people in my religiousness, taking one extreme to another.

And none of my very close friends are not religious, but none of them are very extremely, extremely too religious. So they're all, I'd say, anywhere between very modern [Modern Orthodox synagogue] 'shabbes kosher' to Chassidish but not over the top. And I will sway between them. I will sway between them. Sometimes I'll go travelling with a friend who's not as frum as me and I'll end up doing things which I wouldn't usually do. So I think there's a lot of pressure in that valve. But sometimes I – and I think friends are a big part of my Judaism, for the good or for the bad.

Interviewer: That's interesting. What I'd love to end off with is an invitation to share an anecdote. A story, a something that might shed light on your lives. Your freedom to jump, how hard but sometimes enriching it is to feel comfortable in lots of worlds.

Chana: I remember going to school and I just wanted to go with a plastic bag like my friends did. I didn't want a new school bag every year. And I remember telling my mother that I don't want a new school bag. I just want a plastic bag like everybody else.

Yehoshua: I mean the first time I was provoked about how open I am or how much I'm a **chameleon** to these things was – I once provoked one of my rabbis in yeshiveh and this was in the first month. I provoked him really badly and on a really tough question. And he gave me an answer and it was an extremely closeminded answer.

And I said, “If you told that answer to anyone else,” I said, I’ll accept it. But if you tell that answer to anyone else, they’re not going to listen you. That’s extremely closeminded.” And what he said after that is probably what shook me the most. He said, “I believe in – he says – I will admit that I am closeminded and I will admit that everything I said is an extremist point of view, but I am comfortable in the position I am and I’m comfortable that I’m closeminded. And that’s my core belief and religion.” And he said to me, “You’re telling me that you are prepared to adapt… you’re not really prepared to close in and hone in on one thing.” And that was one of the biggest things that shook me. I was like, “Cool, I can adapt, but on a deeper level, where do I **click**?

Chana: But I think that’s Judaism. We’re all on a ladder on various **rungs**, but anyone above us is an extremist and anyone below us –

Yehoshua: Anyone below us is not Jewish.

Shmul: That question that you were saying, who you are and where do you come from – I think – and as you said, we’re all evolving. If you ask my father that question or even my mother that question, I think both of them would be able to give you an answer because I think at the age of 50 plus, you know who you are. You know where you came from and you’re proud of it and you can embrace it. And yeah, but I’m saying I – I’m Harold [his secular name] from [Chassidic school], so that’s the contrast for you. So if you –

Yehoshua: I’ve actually asked my father before some of these – a little while back, years ago, when I had the balls to provoke him and he – and this is why, in hindsight, I see him as a disciplined man that taught me **religion through discipline** was – he said he’s religious because of discipline. When he grew up, his father never gave him an option. He woke up at 6:00 AM to go to *minyen* because that was *minyen*. There was no such thing as a 7.00 AM *minyen*, it didn’t exist in our world. 6:00 AM *minyen*, you didn’t eat breakfast before you *daven*. You definitely didn’t work before you *daven*. You definitely didn’t come late. And when my grandfather passed away, I coincidentally was going through my struggle at school and switching between [Chassidic school] and [Litvish school]. And my father once turned to me and he said to me – and this was six months after my grandfather passed away – he said, “You know what? When my father passed away, I could have also curled up in a ball.” I literally didn’t get out of my bed. And he said, “I could have also not gotten out of bed and done things, but you get up and do it because that’s what you do and eventually you love it.” And I think today, that’s – I can’t answer for him if that’s where he feels comfortable, but I found that, yeah, that’s his place of where he’s been and where he’s going.

Chana: My grandfather, my mother’s father, who is probably the **root** of all of our **non-conforming issues**, he recently said to me something which resonated. He said, “Life is like a **soccer** game. You’ve got to **grab the ball**, look at your goal, **put your blinkers on** and get the ball in the goal.” And I liked it because we’re always surrounded by different people with different situations and different environments. And you have to constantly think about what is my goal, where do you want to go with this? And at times, you just have to not look around you, don’t get distracted by what’s going on and just focus on what you want as a person and get your ball in the goal.

Yehoshua: And sometimes you miss it.

Commented [User21]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels participants use to define their substantive identity content rather than relying on researcher-dictated scales.

Chana uses her grandfather's **"soccer game"** metaphor—keeping "blinkers on" to get the "ball in the goal"—to define her current focus on **"consciously parenting"**.

Cross-reference: See comment above (^^)

Commented [User22]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This methodology operationalises **nested developmental systems**, showing how macro-level factors are filtered through relational dynamics to shape individual identity.

Relational-Level (Micro/Micro-systemic): The siblings trace their identity standards to their **grandfather**, who is described as the **"root of all of our non-conforming issues"** and the standard to which they all aspire. Yehoshua describes the **"good cop, bad cop"** dynamic of his parents, where his father provided **"discipline"** and his mother provided **"inspiration"**.

Cross-reference: Theme continues also above (@@)

Chana: Sometimes you miss it. But I think I really like that because I am a focused person and I'm determined. And I've recently discovered this **new mum superpower** where you do anything for your kids. So I think it – yeah, it's just I'm constantly questioning. And I'm a person who wants a rich life, who wants quality. I seek answers. I want that depth and fullness in my life and that's why religion and being Jewish and being connected can change and can adapt to the situations that I'm in or what I want for my kids. But yeah, I do often think about what he said, just where's my goal and where's my soccer ball and let's just get it in the goal.

Interviewer: Yehoshua, you remind me of students I've taught before… There's different reasons why students push back. Sometimes they need to know a teacher cares about them. They need to know they're smart and really prepared their lessons well because otherwise they don't care, in which case, why should the *students* listen? Sometimes that's how we learn, by jousting with people. Isn't the *gemara* one big argument? Shmul, do you have a final anecdote you can share?

Shmul: What was your anecdote question again?

Interviewer: A short story or image that captures who you are and where you've come from. Or something that you remember from growing up that stayed with you, that maybe informs the way you are now or what you strive for.

Shmul: I mean I know this is going to sound weird, but I watch my father get up there at [Modern Orthodox synagogue] on – my father loves going to the early *minyen*. He's an early bird and he likes to go to the early minyen. And he'd get up there and he'd go up to the – they'd give him aliya because he's well-respected and he's at [Modern Orthodox synagogue]. And he gets up there and he goes, with this *Chassidisheh havureh* and he says "*Borchi*" and the rest of the brucheh. And the whole shul look at him, and go, "Ah, you're from [Chassidic community] and whatever it is." And he's very comfortable with that, extremely comfortable. He doesn't change. When he's on the phone, go wog because he's surrounded by wogs and he doesn't change wherever he goes. He's very, very comfortable. I've never seen my father ever take his yarmulke off. I don't even think I've ever seen him in a business sense, put on a cap. He is who is. He's never changed. He's always been comfortable with who is because if you do what's right – there's a Mark Twain quote, I think, that you're never wrong to do the right thing, or something like that. And I'm just like – I think that's very much my father's way, is that you do the right thing and then you're not – there is no – you're not answerable to anyone if you're doing the right thing. And that's something I think I strive towards. I know that's where I come from.

That's also something I strive towards. I'd love to be very comfortable with who I am, to the point where when you ask me who I am [and], I'd be able to give you a defined answer because I'm very, very comfortable and I know who I am. I've discovered who I am. I'm very happy to walk into a business meeting. I'm happy to go into shul, happy to go to [Chassidic synagogue], to go to [Modern Orthodox synagogue]. And the funniest thing is if you think that it'd be – but if you think that someone who doesn't conform is not well liked because no one likes a person who isn't willing to conform. No one likes a person who walks into the room and argues with everyone about their views. Everyone likes a person who comes in there – the people pleaser is a person who walks in there and comes in and schmoozes everyone up, but he goes to [Modern Orthodox synagogue], he puts on his kipa sruga and when he goes to [Chassidic synagogue], he puts on his hat. People

prefer that. It's easier to be that. But at the end of the day, people – from what I've observed is the most respectable and admirable people are the people that are comfortable with who they are and that they can walk into a room and think they get the utmost respect because they stand true to their values and they're not putting an image on. And they're real people, and there's no element of making things up and being fake. They're genuine. To be genuine, you have to be consistent, and yeah.

Chana: That's well put.

Interviewer: Amazing. Thank you.

So what I'm going to do is I'm going to type this up. I'll e-mail the transcript back to you. It's yours to do with as you wish. But as a researcher, I am bound by confidentiality. I'll invite you to choose a pseudonym and if I quote anything from the transcript, it will be deidentified and with any identifying information removed.

Yehoshua: As in a name?

Interviewer: A pseudonym, a fake name, one that you would recognise but that is not your real name.

Yehoshua: [Long pause] There's three of us in one family, not a single one of us have the same definition of being Jewish –

<overtalking>

Yehoshua: And you want to quantify it?

Interviewer: Quantitative research is the bekyiut, the breadth. Qualitative research is the iyun, the depth. An hour and a half with you offers depth. They're different kinds of magic and they each have different benefits.

Suri: Hi. To label and give a term for me is hard because I find my Jewish life very complicated, in the sense that I grew up balanced. I know that 'balanced' looks different to everyone. I went to a very Chassidish, Hareidi school. But we were allowed to watch movies and read non-Jewish books. Go to beaches and dress the way we wanted to. Things that my friends were not allowed to do. And we were not allowed to talk about it in that school either. [Laughs] I felt like I had the best of both worlds. I loved the way that I grew up. With respect to Judaism, we were very Orthodox and very law-abiding Jews, but at the same time we got to have a taste of other things in a very balanced, normal way. I really respect the way my parents did that and I hope that I can achieve the same for my kids, even though we have taken a bit of a different turn. We were only supposed to have been a Kollel family for a year and it has been many more than that! My husband learns in Kollel. He is loving it and I have a high respect for Toireh learning. And I think I get that from my mother. She is very passionate about Toireh and everything. But I would never have seen myself in this kind of lifestyle, so many years later, being supported by our parents. He was going to go to work after a short Kollel experience and work in the "real world", but [pauses].

So where do I see myself Jewishly? Is weird because, again, I always, I grew up in this very Hareidi community, but we were a little different. we got to do our own thing. And the same is happening now. I'm in a community where all my friends'

husbands are in learning full time, from early to late. It's intense and they all dress quite hareidi. But I'm a little different. I dress a little more modern. Nothing crazy. Just not like them. And **I find myself doing something different but also trying to stay within a community, trying to fit in.** And it is a bit of a weird feeling sometimes, but I do like it.

It's a very big dichotomy, it's quite complex for me. There's a piece of me that really wants to fit in, want to be similar and dress the way they dress, speak the way they speak. Things like that. But there's that other part that says, 'No, I like this balance. I love being involved in this Toireh lifestyle, but at night we can sit and watch Netflix together. I love that and I think that's quite rare. But I love that. But then again that piece of me says, "but I don't fit in enough. Wouldn't it be easier if I was just, you know, similar." …

My sister and I had a different experience. Our home changed a lot when the boys came along. My parents did things very differently. I'd never seen that side of them. It really changed the dynamics of the family…

What shaped me?

I have very high expectations for my life, my marriage, my kids. And I think that was very much honed in by my Mum pushing me and my sister really hard. We did heaps of afterschool activities, we learned sports, languages, instruments – which they boys never got! Tons of stuff. It was crazy. Not at the time – at the time I thought it was normal and just a busy life. So all these things – **my mother pushed us hard, but I feel like that gave me a very big drive in life**. Because now I can see how far I can push myself. How far I can come!

The choice of seminary was also critical in who I am. I say "the choice" but it was not my choice. It was a choice my parents made, because they decided for me. I went to […] a hareidi seminary. It was the highest hareidi environment you could be in! It was really eye-opening and intense for me. I didn't enjoy it socially. But it taught me a lot about finding friends. It was big learning curve for me. And the way they spoke about a Toireh lifestyle – it was really intense. And I laughed at it but now here I am! I'm living it! [Laughs] Different to similar to what they were talking about. They taught me that Toireh can fill your home with so much goodness and I feel that. And I'm attached to that. The rest came from my mother. [Pauses] School didn't give me an appreciation for Judaism. At all. And I sort of resent them for that. I didn't get any, see any appreciation for - it was all factual, and nothing was warm and heartful. I didn't know at the time and I didn't *feel* it at the time. But looking back, "Why, why didn't they show the beauty in this lifestyle." It was all very, "You have to wear your skirt down to here" and "your elbows have to be covered over there". Like, there was nothing really meaningful about the way that they taught us about how to be Jewish.

The person who I married as also played a huge part in this because he is very genuine and passionate about his choice of lifestyle. And that really attracted me to this lifestyle. He is very genuine about it and lives it in a way that feels really authentic. It doesn't feel forced, or something I have to do. It feels like something we both want. And I really value that way of looking, look at things. That has impacted on me hugely.

END OF INTERVIEW